

The US Marines

Among the first American units to arrive in Vietnam, the Marines came to the fore during the Tet Offensive, when their reputation for being the US's toughest infantry force was put to the test at Con Thien, Khe Sanh, and in the bloody battle to retake Hue.

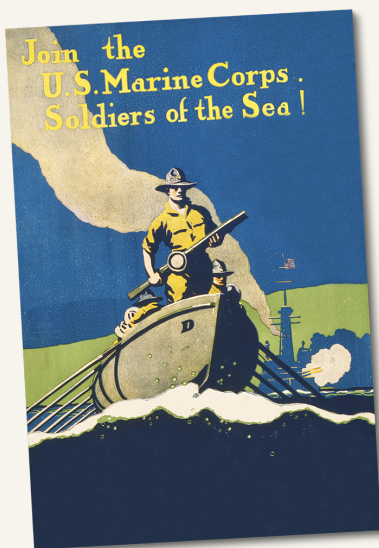
◀◀ BEFORE

The Marines have served in nearly every US overseas conflict since the corps was founded during the Revolutionary War.

BORN TO BE BOLD

On November 10, 1775, the **Continental Congress** instructed Samuel Nicholas to raise two battalions of **seaborne soldiers**. Their first mission was a raid on the Bahamas in 1776. Their nickname **leathernecks** derives from the stiff neckpieces of their early uniforms.

In World War I, the Germans called the Marines devil dogs for their ferocious performance at the **Battle of Belleau Wood** in 1918. In World War II, the Marines rose to world renown for their bravery in **battles against the Japanese** in the Pacific.



WORLD WAR I RECRUITMENT POSTER

The United States Marine Corps (USMC) was an important component of US operations in the war. Between 1965 and 1975, around 450,000 Marines served in the conflict; some 13,000 were killed in combat, and more than 88,000 were wounded. Fifty-seven Marines were awarded the Medal of Honor for bravery under fire.

Recruitment and training

The Marine Corps is a self-contained combined-arms force with its own artillery and airpower, but it is best known for its infantry—rapid response ground forces that engage in close-range combat. The corps is part of the US Department of the Navy, reflecting its original role of supporting naval campaigns.

In Vietnam, the vast majority of Marine recruits were volunteers, typically between the ages of 18 and 20. (Only 10 percent of draftees became Marines.) They signed up for a minimum of three years, although this was reduced to two during the buildup of US troops